



Game Design Document: Apex Swarm

1. Executive Summary

Concept: A portrait-mode, hyper-fast "Bullet Heaven" survival game. The player controls a cyber-warrior facing endless swarms of neon-glitch enemies. **Platform:** Mobile (Android & iOS). **Target Audience:** Mid-core mobile gamers looking for high-intensity, short-session action (3-8 minute runs). **Monetization:** Hybrid (Rewarded Ads, Interstitials, IAP).

2. The Core Loops

The secret to hybrid-casual success is balancing the short-term thrill with long-term goals.

2.1 The Core Loop (Short-Term / Active Gameplay)

1. **Survive & Move:** Player uses a virtual joystick (one thumb) to navigate.
2. **Auto-Attack:** The game handles aiming and shooting based on equipped weapons.
3. **Harvest XP:** Enemies drop data-gems upon death.
4. **Draft Upgrades:** Collecting enough gems triggers a pause, offering 3 random, stackable upgrades (Rogue-lite mechanics).
5. **Climax:** Survive until the timer runs out or defeat the sector boss.

2.2 The Meta Loop (Long-Term / Idle Progression)

1. **Collect Credits:** Enemies and bosses drop permanent currency (Credits).
2. **Die/Complete Run:** Player returns to the Main Menu.
3. **Permanent Upgrades:** Player spends Credits to permanently increase Base HP, Base Damage, or Starting Speed.
4. **Unlock:** Reach new levels to unlock new weapon types in the drafting pool.

3. Gameplay Mechanics

3.1 Controls

- **Input:** Single-touch drag anywhere on the screen creates a dynamic virtual joystick.
- **Constraint:** Player moves at a fixed speed. Skill comes from dodging and herding enemies, not aiming.

3.2 Combat & Weapons

- *Kinetic Blaster:* Shoots nearest enemy.
- *Plasma Orbit:* Orbs rotate around the player, damaging enemies that get too close.
- *Chain Lightning:* Bounces between clustered enemies (great for swarms).

- **Weapon Evolution:** If a player maxes out a weapon (Level 5) and holds a specific passive item, it "Evolves" into a screen-clearing super weapon.

3.3 Enemy Ecosystem

- **Swarmers:** Fast, low HP. Move in massive groups to restrict player movement.
- **Brutes:** Slow, high HP. Act as moving walls.
- **Shooters:** Keep their distance and fire slow-moving projectiles the player must dodge.
- **Bosses:** Appear at specific minute marks (e.g., 3:00, 6:00). High HP, unique bullet-hell attack patterns. Drop a "Magnet" or a chest when killed.

4. Monetization Integration (Player-First)

We do not punish players with ads; we offer them as lifelines.

- **The Revive (Rewarded Ad):** When the player dies, prompt: *"Warning: Critical Failure. Reboot Systems? (Watch Ad to Revive with 50% HP)"*. High conversion rate.
- **The Multiplier (Rewarded Ad):** On the Game Over screen: *"You earned 500 Credits. Watch Ad to multiply by 3x!"*
- **The Tax (Interstitial):** Shown only if the player returns to the main menu *without* watching a rewarded ad, capped at 1 per 5 minutes.
- **IAP:** "Premium Hacker License" (\$4.99) - Removes all Interstitial ads and gives the 3x Multiplier automatically without watching ads.

5. Art & Audio Direction

- **Visuals:** "Neon Cyber-Goth". High contrast. The background is a dark, muted blueprint/grid. Enemies are glowing, solid colors (Neon Pink, Acid Green) so they are instantly readable on a small screen.
- **Juice (Game Feel):** Heavy screen shake on boss kills. Satisfying, cascading "pop" sounds when collecting massive chains of XP gems. Leveling up must pause the screen with a massive, flashy animation.